television, the internet and of course the political class in each country.

The return of the great leader who promises to solve all problems – to take a stagnant economy and make it purr, to take joblessness by the throat and make it cough out jobs. This is a tradition that seeks its emotions in will, distracting from the terrible conditions of everyday life, the perils of miners or the futility of farmers. Argument is considered a waste of time, only action is valued. Democracy is given lip service but its constraints are mocked. National glory makes its return, but careful not to mimic fascism – an embarrassment for the elite. Justification for military rule has made a comeback after a brief moment in the 1990s when the West promoted 'democracy' above all else. The rhetoric of counter-terrorism and of social instability has allowed the army to leave the barracks from Egypt to Thailand – with liberal elites taking refuge in the Generals.

Turkey's Recep Tayyip Erdogan and India's Narendra Modi are powerful examples of free market or authoritarian populism. They portray themselves as the sharp swords to cut the knots that bind progress. It is acceptable for them to call for austerity – not as a means for personal virtue, but as the suffering of the people for a greater good (in effect, for the greater good of large business linked to their political parties). The long arm of the law, even short of outright military dictatorship, can smash workers' protests and political protests and arrest critical journalists for sedition.

Behind doors, the Masters of the World – the G7 states – continue their shenanigans, most notably through trade agreements. Policy space for the South continues to be constrained by them in international institutions, allowing them to subsidise their own big business but allowing the Global South little freedom to protect their economies. The pressure on the Global South to dismantle their food security systems in the World Trade Organisation is one such example. Another is the Trade in Services Agreement (TISA) pushed by the US and the European Union and their 'Really Good Friends' (a strange term used by the US and the EU to refer to the bloc they have put together). The bulk of the Really Good Friends involved in the TISA negotiations are from the upper-income countries, with only two lower-income states (Pakistan and Paraguay) in the process. The TISA pushes for the turbo-charged privatisation of public services.

Alongside the TISA is the Trans-Pacific Partnership (TPP), a mechanism to export the North American Free Trade Agreement outwards across the Pacific Ocean and down into South America. The TPP has been negotiated utterly in secret and, if not for WikiLeaks, the entire content of the discussion would be unknown to the public. Domestic laws would be overriden by the TPP, in